Vanguard, Aegis, Marksman

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by decay

Summary

“Is it so hard to be honest?” Phainon asks, instead, and ignores Mydei’s groan. His fingers press into the bare skin of Mydei’s shoulder, and he can feel the battle-rough calluses on Phainon’s palm where his claymore’s hilt has rested day after day, swing after swing. Mydei thinks to swat Phainon’s hand away, but hesitates long enough that Phainon grows bolder, leaning even closer into Mydei’s space as if to demand his attention.

“Bold of you to make demands while you are a visitor in my chambers, hero.” Mydei parries the question bluntly, glancing at Phainon’s hand that lingers on his shoulder and weighing his options. He cannot decide if he'd rather Phainon stay or leave, and splashing him then kicking him out is a tempting variant.

“Then tell me to go, Mydeimos,” Phainon says, speaking his name with purpose. He is so close that his warm breath fans Mydei’s face. “And I will.”

Notes

Dedicated to vanishresponse - being able to chat about 3.0 together has genuinely gotten me through the past few months. I'm so glad we're friends. <3

There are probably canon inaccuracies in here (like, technically I think Dan Heng was there for part of this fight, but this isn’t about him LOL), sorry in advance!

[Minor edits made because I forgot the Chrysos Heirs have golden blood ... Oops!]

See the end of the work for more notes

Combat between two who cannot know death is a moment that stretches endlessly; an unending cycle of blood, battle, and rebirth. Every strike of Nikador's golden lance reverberates through Mydei's gauntlets, through his muscle and sinew, rattling his bones within his skin. The Titan fights the way he does: savagely, unyieldingly, without care of their own safety, just like an embodiment of Castrum Kremnos and their people. There is no finesse in the Lance of Fury's strikes, none of the captivating technique that lets Phainon keep pace with Mydei when they spar - just the battle-hunger of a mad god caught in death throes for eternity.

It could have been minutes, hours, or days since Mydei sent Phainon and the travelers from beyond the sky away from the ruins of his home and the wrath of his god. The longer he lives, even off the battlefield, the more he marks the passage of time by death; Mydei himself has not changed since he grew into the prime of what should have been a mortal life. A war is marked by how dark the ground grows with blood, how much his armored boots sink into the mud of gore, how few remain while he continues to cleave a path forward. His life outside combat is marked by who remains at his side while he remains stuck in time.

This battle is marked in cycles of pain - a constant crescendo of combat, a cresting climax, and a blistering, agonizing, comet-tail contest of attrition. In these cycle-end skirmishes, where Mydei and Nikador all but tear themselves apart to pull the other down first, Mydei faintly envies his god's madness.

Are Strife's godly mind and body capable of feeling excruciating sensations analogous to bone shattering within muscle, tearing through the sinew and skin, and knowing that they must rise on broken limbs and raise their head and meet their end? Do they, too, feel instinctive, crawling dread claw up their throat when their body bends and breaks and they are thrown into that moment of twilight, even after a lifetime of death?

Kremnoans fight with nothing less than all they are imbued in every strike. They fight knowing that every strike might be their last, and if it is, they'll accept nothing less than to go out in a blaze of valor. Mydei, too, fights this

way - it’s ingrained in his mind and soul, hammered into his marrow - but no strike will ever be his last. And yet, he never pulls his punches.

Nikador’s lance clangs against the metal of Mydei’s gauntlets over and over, metal shrieking against metal, weapons cutting through the otherwise oppressive silence of Castrum Kremnos. The sound soothes Mydei, in a way - otherwise, it is only his shouts of exertion and pain that echo through the ruins of his home.

“Mydei!”

Phainon’s shout of his name injects life into the stagnant loop of combat. There is no hesitation as Mydei instinctively twists his body to the left, catching Nikador’s lance with one gauntlet and making room for Phainon’s claymore to swing up from the right, slamming into the edge of the lance beside him. No words are needed as they parry the strike in sync, standing shoulder to shoulder. This time, Nikador’s lance does not bear down so heavily that Mydei thinks it might push him into the floor. Phainon is warm at his side.

“You’re here,” Mydei says in acknowledgement, jumping back in step with Phainon as Nikador draws back their lance once more. He intends to glance at Phainon and then return his attention to the fight, but ends up looking a moment too long when he sees Phainon unabashedly scanning him up and down for injury.

“Sorry I’m late,” Phainon says, eyes flitting back to Mydei’s. There is nothing of note for Phainon to see - some scrapes and bruises from this round, but Mydei’s last revival was not very long ago.

Mydei just scoffs, a nonverbal rebuttal to the apology. He is used to fighting alone, but he won’t tell Phainon his presence isn’t desired. “Sword up, hero,” Mydei says instead, sinking back into a combat-ready stance. He gives Phainon precisely the amount of space he needs to swing his claymore, but stands close enough to cover his back. He watches the glint of Nikador’s lance as they raise it high, the tip aimed downwards. “Are you ready?”

Phainon, too, readies himself for battle. His claymore is held to his right, opposite Mydei, and he gives Mydei a grin, disarming in its openness. “Always,” Phainon says, and there is no fear or hesitation in his tone or expression. He is honest, confident, and so fearless that he does not seem out of place in Castrum Kremnos. He is so bright that Mydei has to look away.

“Focus,” Mydei chides, looking back at Nikador. Phainon laughs, then, and Mydei does not know if he’s scolding Phainon or himself.

Mydei had been asked once, many years ago, what dreams lie at the bottom of his heart. When his answer was metaphorical, he’d been asked instead, *“A vanguard, an aegis, or a marksman?”*

[Little crown prince Mydeimos had answered with none of them. No lance or shield or bow was forged for him - no weapon or armor could grant him the dreams of adventure and light that fluttered in the depths of his heart. But when he was forced to choose, he found his answer. Not with a lance or bow or shield, but with his whole body.]

The answer is obvious from a single glance - no armor adorns Mydei’s chest, nor is he built for anything but offense. He’s a singular arrow shot into the ranks of his enemies to tear them down one by one, not the archer at the bow nor the *aegis* to stand as shield between blade and bone.

Mydei fights with calculated abandon, willing to suffer for every strike so long as no injury goes unrepaid. He leaps forward to trade blows with Nikador when Phainon catches the lance on his claymore, uncaring of how far past the limits of his body he pushes. He pivots on his heel to cover Phainon’s back when he swings his claymore wide, stopping Nikador’s strikes with his bare body, trusting Phainon to follow up and keep the rhythm of the fight.

Mydei is the weapon himself. He is the vanguard, the aegis, the marksman - but he is alone. He stands at the frontline, he never allows himself to fall without getting up again, he launches himself into enemy ranks. It has

always been this way, and in Mydei's most pessimistic moments he thinks it may always remain like this.

And yet, as Nikador's lance reaches its apex and cleaves downwards after a sweeping blow that knocked Mydei to the ground, he has staggered to his feet and planted himself in front of Phainon.

At once, the lance is stained with another layer of molten gold blood and Phainon's shout is all but drowned out by the sickening squelch and snap of Nikador's weapon passing clean through Mydei's chest - breaking the breastbone and puncturing his insides - and despite all of Mydei's efforts, just barely stops short of piercing Phainon behind him.

Phainon is shouting, still, but Mydei can't process it as the ruins of Castrum Kremnos tilt around him when Nikador pulls their lance back. It unsheathes itself from Mydei with a wet sound, followed by the splatter of shimmering blood that cascades from the wound. The pain is so intense it eclipses into icy shock, and only when Mydei coughs, another waterfall of liquid gold falling from his lips, does the searing burn of it begin to ignite through his body. It makes his muscles seize and shudder, and then the ground is coming up to meet him.

Instead of Mydei's armored knees crashing to the hard stone beneath him, a firm arm winds around his waist and holds him up with enough care to jolt him back to the battlefield. When he turns his head, ignoring the blistering sensation of his body knitting itself together again, he is met with Phainon's wide blue eyes, racing thoughts so obviously at the tip of his tongue as his lips part hesitantly, moonlight hair sticking to his face with sweat and grime.

"Eyes forward," Mydei chides again, and his voice comes out like a death rattle as his half-formed lungs struggle to give him air. His chest constricts, surely from the effort. "Not on me."

Phainon's eyes flicker from Mydei's face to the gold dripping from his chin to his chest, where his muscles and flesh are growing back together. There's a distant look on Phainon's face, like he gets sometimes when he talks

about himself without saying very much at all - but Mydei knows the feeling that pulls at the edge of his lips. What is it, if not loneliness?

“Phainon,” Mydei says, when the moment stretches on too long and Phainon’s gaze becomes too heavy for Mydei to want to unpack. His voice is a wet rasp. Mydei doesn't often call Phainon by name - for he has his own suspicions to Phainon’s secrets, not that they are anything for him to ask about - but the word is enough for Phainon to snap out of it.

Phainon’s fingers curl tighter around his waist briefly, as if loath to let go, before he lets out a little exhale. “I know,” Phainon says, but his eyes keep drifting downwards towards the mortal wound healing all on its own. “But -“

Mydei growls in exertion as he leans over to grasp Phainon’s other hand, hanging at his side and still holding his claymore, and forces him to swing it up. The blade clangs against Nikador’s lance, and Phainon instantly refocuses and helps Mydei repel the strike.

“Not the time,” Mydei says, breathing still ragged. He’ll need another few moments to be able to parry a strike like that on his own.

In the moment when Nikador’s lance arcs up again, Mydei hears Phainon exhale softly in resignation. He feels it, too, and it’s then when he realizes that they are in an overly intimate embrace. The sensation of Phainon’s arm around him, against his back, hand on his waist, is so distracting that he only belatedly realizes that he’s whole again.

When Phainon acquiesces and loosens his grasp on Mydei to take up a combat stance again, it is Mydei who is last to let go of his hand.

Mydei has no desire to linger upon their return to Okhema. He merely glances at Strife’s Coreflame in Phainon’s hand, claps Phainon on the shoulder, and turns away to retire to his chambers, more than happy to let the other man deal with Aglaea’s questions.

As soon as the doors shut behind him, Mydei removes what little armor he wears and tosses the gold and grime-stained pieces off to the side to clean later, his clothes and jewelry following shortly after. For the first time in a long while, Mydei's thoughts are blessedly quiet - bone deep exhaustion surely plays a part, but there's a deeper sense of peace knowing that Nikador's undying body no longer haunts Castrum Kremnos. Faintly, Mydei wonders what it would take to put him to rest, too.

A long, slow exhale escapes Mydei as he lowers his aching body into the pleasantly warm water of his personal bath and leans back against the smooth stone, sitting on one of the low steps. Briefly, his eyes drift shut as he submerges his heavy limbs and sore muscles. In the water blessed by Phagousa, the dull gold clouds of now-dried blood and grime that Mydei washes from his skin quickly fade as the bath purifies itself.

And then there is a familiar knock on his doors.

"Enter," Mydei says, without bothering to get up or care that he's unclothed. He knows who it is, and Phainon has barely stepped inside when he tilts his head back languidly, watching the other man close the door. Mydei pushes his hair from his eyes, the now-wet strands dripping droplets of water down his cheek. "What is it?"

"Nothing. I just wanted to check on you and see how you're recovering," Phainon says, and although he smiles that picture-perfect hero smile, there's a heaviness in his voice and a tension in his shoulders that Mydei can't help but hone in on. His eyes narrow in displeasure, but Phainon presses on before he can speak. "How do you feel?"

"Tired," Mydei says, honestly, and Phainon seems surprised for a moment before he schools his expression back to concern. "But otherwise fine." Mydei is always fine.

Phainon's gaze remains respectfully on Mydei's face and, though it seems like he's digesting Mydei's answer, he makes no move to speak further. He is as still as a statue except for the growing furrow in his brow, making a matching frown pull at Mydei's lips.

“Are you injured?” he asks, and Phainon seems to be shaken out of his thoughts. Mydei didn’t think Phainon was hurt beyond the normal wear and tear of battle, but if something wasn’t wrong, why would he be lingering around Mydei’s chambers when his trial looms?

“Thanks to you, I’m perfectly healthy,” Phainon says. There is a hollow cheer in his voice and a heaviness in the way he pats his chest where Nikador’s lance would have pierced him, if Mydei hadn’t taken the strike for him. Mydei just hums in acknowledgement, but has nothing else to add.

Phainon is silent for a moment, and seems to debate with himself before stepping forward, his steps echoing against the stone floor. He moves hesitantly, at first, until he sees Mydei simply raise an eyebrow but otherwise have no reaction to his approach. Phainon takes a seat at the edge of the bath beside Mydei, drawing one knee up to his chest, and holds Mydei’s gaze. He still has to look down from this angle, but he’s much closer.

“Why did you go so far?”

All this, just to ask a nonsense question? Mydei stops himself from sighing, instead merely shrugging. The resulting ripples lap gently against the stone ledges of the bath. “Any warrior would do everything they can to ensure they and their allies come out victorious in battle,” he says, matter of fact. “Is that not common sense?”

“Sure,” Phainon says slowly, blatantly searching Mydei’s expression with a look of near-fragility that looks a little too close to a small, sad animal for his liking. Mydei resists the urge to look away. “But it still hurts, doesn’t it? There had to have been another way - seeing you in pain, injured, *dying* in front of me, I -“

“I am not afraid of pain. Or death,” Mydei says, when Phainon’s sentence starts to take on a tone of earnestness that he doesn’t know how to face. He stops there, letting the words wither in the air between them, but there’s a second half of the sentence that lingers unsaid, of what he *is* afraid of. Mydei won’t say it. Phainon just looks at him and Mydei stares back, watching realization sharpen his watery gaze to piercing shards of sky blue.

For a fleeting moment, Mydei wonders if Phainon isn't destined for Aquila's Coreflame instead.

"Let it go, hero," Mydei says, finally, in a rare display of acquiescence. His tone is solemn, but lacks the bite it often bears when Phainon plies him with too many questions. "As you said, I am recovering - should you not leave me to rest?"

"No," Phainon says, in an equally rare display of outward petulance that makes Mydei raise his eyebrows incredulously. Phainon's tenacity is well-known, but he also carries the image of the perfect, gentle, gentlemanly Heir - except with Mydei.

"'No'?" Mydei can't help but parrot him, scoffing. "You have other things to do. You should be preparing for the Coreflame's trial. If not this, then what have you been working for?"

"Finish what you were saying earlier," Phainon presses instead, bracing one hand against the edge of the bath and leaning forward into Mydei's space. Mydei's rebuttal dies on his tongue, and his mouth is dry when Phainon's steady, still-piercing gaze pins him in place. Suddenly, the pleasantly warm water surrounding him feels like it's overheating, and Mydei feels off-balance with Phainon sitting so close to his side.

"No." This time, it is Mydei's turn to refuse. Before he even speaks, he is watching Phainon's expression to see how that piercing blue unfocuses slightly with irritation. He watches the way Phainon's brow pinches ever so slightly as the word sinks in and he begins to formulate some new, annoying argument.

"Mydei, please, just -"

That's the word. Annoying.

With a quiet growl of irritation, Mydei reaches up and threads his fingers through the soft moonlight hair at the nape of Phainon's neck, uncaring that he drips water down the column of Phainon's throat, taking advantage of his momentary confusion to yank him down. The movement sends new aches

through Mydei’s already battered muscles, and Phainon’s forehead knocks with his before he manages to steady himself with a hand on Mydei’s shoulder - but the cessation of Phainon’s nagging as their lips meet is worth it.

It is not an elegant kiss - it’s half teeth and mostly surprise and lasts just a few fleeting seconds - but the blessed silence and Phainon’s wide-eyed look of wonder when Mydei pulls back is worth the inconvenience.

“Drop it,” Mydei says, and though he entirely means to say it with a stern bite, the command instead nestles quietly between them. Phainon’s eyes flicker down to follow the shape of his lips, and even when Mydei lets go of the back of his head, he does not move. Mydei supposes this is answer enough. He may have tacitly ceded victory of this argument to Phainon, but in this instance he finds he does not entirely mind losing, even if discomfort prickles along the back of his neck.

But Phainon continues to ignore Mydei’s words.

“Is it so hard to be honest?” Phainon asks, instead, and ignores Mydei’s groan. His fingers press into the bare skin of Mydei’s shoulder, and he can feel the battle-rough calluses on Phainon’s palm where his claymore’s hilt has rested day after day, swing after swing. Mydei thinks to swat Phainon’s hand away, but hesitates long enough that Phainon grows bolder, leaning even closer into Mydei’s space as if to demand his attention.

“Bold of you to make demands while you are a visitor in my chambers, hero.” Mydei parries the question bluntly, glancing at Phainon’s hand that lingers on his shoulder and weighing his options. He cannot decide if he'd rather Phainon stay or leave, and splashing him then kicking him out is a tempting variant.

“Then tell me to go, Mydeimos,” Phainon says, speaking his name with purpose. He is so close that his warm breath fans Mydei’s face. “And I will.”

Mydei is silent for a long moment, and Phainon does not move. He doesn’t say anything else, nor does his quiet stare implore Mydei to rush to a

decision. Instead, he is patient, as if simply content to watch the droplets of water slowly fall from Mydei's hair.

"Do whatever you want," Mydei says, eventually. He closes his eyes briefly and leans back against the ledge of the bath, though he doesn't move away from Phainon or shrug off his hand. "But I'm not getting out."

"That's fine," Phainon says, and Mydei can hear the smile in his voice before he opens his eyes again and sees it. When he meets Phainon's gaze again, that sky blue in his eyes is infused with heat. "I'll just have to join you."

Mydei lets out a noise somewhere between a scoff and a laugh, and turns his head to unabashedly watch as Phainon makes quick work of removing his armor and clothes. The pieces fall to the ground in a careless pile, and Phainon steps into the water as Mydei's eyes rove the well-built muscle of Phainon's body. There is unmasked appreciation in his gaze, but he also makes no move to conceal the displeasure of seeing the occasional bruise, scrape, or cut.

Phainon laughs quietly as he enters the bath and boldly steps between Mydei's spread legs. Mydei has to look up from where he's sitting, and he's met with an expression tinged with desire as Phainon finally lets himself look lower than Mydei's face, now freely drinking in the sight of his bare body. When Phainon's eyes flicker up to Mydei's again, he just grins.

"What now, hero?" Mydei asks when Phainon keeps standing there. His question comes out like a taunt, but even he can hear the smile in his voice, even if he doesn't show it.

Phainon hums in response and just sinks down into a kneeling position in front of Mydei, between his thighs, close enough that the water laps against Mydei's skin. From the tease in Phainon's eyes and in his grin, Mydei knows this is on purpose. Phainon looks just like a knight kneeling in front of royalty. Mydei swallows, trying to focus more on the way that droplets of water slide down Phainon's bare skin, over his clavicle and between his pectoral muscles, instead of his errant thoughts; instead of how the single-minded intensity in Phainon's gaze makes arousal spark in his gut.

Phainon only holds the pose for a few moments before he rises slightly and leans forward, hovering over Mydei. When he reaches out, Mydei makes no move to stop him. Phainon's fingers skim the bare skin of his sides, and he curses. It's an airy word buried in the exhale forced out of him at the light touches. For all this body has endured - years of drowning, of living only by dying, of wielding himself as a weapon and letting himself break against blades - all it takes is that one gentle touch to make him shudder.

Instead of continuing lower, Phainon's hands skim down Mydei's sides and then back up, nails brushing teasingly over his nipples, palms smoothing over his chest, and then one hand cupping his face. Phainon rubs his thumb over the rise of Mydei's cheek and then shifts his attention to the side, carefully undoing the braid in his hair. Phainon gently sets the golden hair accessory on the ledge of the bath and runs his fingers through Mydei's long hair, untangling the strands and rubbing flecks of blood from them.

The gesture is more tender than Mydei expected, and once again he feels thrown off balance. Phainon is so close that all it takes is a slight shift for Mydei to press up against him, and they both groan as their stiffening cocks slide against each other. The sensation sends pleasure sparking through Mydei's veins, and he can feel them both grow to full hardness against each other when he does it again.

When Phainon reaches between them to take both cocks in hand and keep them pressed together, Mydei jerks involuntarily at the sudden jolt of sensitivity. The movement only feeds into the growing heat and causes the water to slosh around them, spilling over the edge of the bath. And when Phainon slowly rubs his hand along their lengths, the smooth glide aided by the water, Mydei's hand shoots out to grasp Phainon's hip, as if to anchor himself.

Phainon is so close that their ragged exhales mingle in the scant space between them, and when Mydei presses his hips up against Phainon again, he can feel the way Phainon's muscles tense under his hand. Mydei's thumb rests against the curve of Phainon's hip bone, and he feels the ample muscle tense again right before Phainon grinds down against him in response.

Each slide and press of their cocks against each other only stokes the growing, burning arousal in Mydei's core. He groans as Phainon continues to drag his hand up and down, occasionally pausing to run his fingers over and around the head of Mydei's cock, teasing the sensitive skin there.

And all the while, Phainon has kept that focused, single-minded, *burning* blue gaze on Mydei. Even as a flush of exertion blooms across his pale skin, even as a captivating moan is dragged from Phainon's lips when Mydei times his thrust upwards with Phainon's movements, even - especially - when Phainon runs his thumb along the slit of Mydei's cock and his head tilts back in pleasure, a rough moan of his own rumbling from his chest.

Mydei still has enough sense that, when Phainon reaches out with his free hand, Mydei does not let him grasp his own bare hand - instead, he turns his palm so that he grasps Phainon's wrist. It's an awkward movement, distracted as he is, but even through the way his head swims with unfamiliar pleasure, he can see Phainon's eyes flicker down to his hand.

"Don't hide from me," Phainon says. His voice is rougher than normal, but he speaks softly. His eyes have taken on that piercing look again, making Mydei feel as exposed as he might in an open field beneath an endless, inescapable blue sky. "You think I don't know how much you've endured?"

And then Phainon turns his other wrist, stroking down the length of Mydei's cock slowly and deliberately, watching Mydei's involuntary shudder as he feels the curve of Phainon's palm and the rise of his calluses, like a map of every time he's stood on the battlefield, every time he's fought and won, because he's still here now.

"Don't hide from me," Phainon says again, when Mydei exhales harshly and closes his eyes. Damned hero, stubborn in all the annoying ways and always perceptive exactly when it's to his advantage. "Mydei," Phainon says, the edge of a whine in his voice, like he's begging for attention, "please?"

"Stop talking," Mydei says, opening his eyes again and trying not to think about how he is out of breath after just two words. He takes a stuttering

inhale, focusing only on the way Phainon touches him, and acquiesces - again. He lets go of Phainon’s wrist and instead grasps his hand, grimacing at the contrast between them. Where Phainon has a warrior’s hand, a physical testament to the life he’s led and the path he’s taken to get here, every swing of his weapon engraved into the skin, Mydei’s skin is smooth and unmarred - as if he’s lived a life of coddled comfort, as if he’s never felt the strife of war. Compared to any Kremnoan, Mydei is disgustingly devoid of marks of battle, if only because death washes away the proof of his suffering.

But Phainon’s face lights up with a grin - an honest one, bright and open - and he eagerly presses his palm into Mydei’s, threading their fingers together and immediately squeezing his hand. Just as Mydei is about to comment, the moment his lips part to speak Phainon surges forward and devours the word before it can escape him, kissing Mydei open mouthed.

Phainon takes advantage of the momentary surprise and the way Mydei jolts, running his tongue along Mydei’s bottom lip before pressing it inside, heated and demanding. Mydei is on the backstep from the start - surprised and still distracted by Phainon’s hand around his cock - and Phainon is relentless. His lips move against Mydei’s as his tongue explores the inside of Mydei’s mouth. Both movements are, somehow, languid and persistent at the same time - as if he’s searching for something.

And if it’s a reaction Phainon was looking for, Mydei has little choice but to give it to him. With no opportunity to catch his breath beforehand, he is quickly running out of air. Already, the room is beginning to feel like it’s spinning. What little he can see beyond Phainon’s half-lidded blue eyes and moonlight hair sticking to his forehead is already blurring.

Mydei is no stranger to losing his breath - drowning, suffocating, or being strangled have never been his deaths of choice, but instead of the primal bolt of fear he’s so used to, this is different. All he feels is heat and touch, somehow both firm and yielding, as if he is buoyed by the rising heat of Phainon against him in the water, tethered by every touch and shared exhale, and anchored right there by Phainon’s undivided attention.

Mydei is beginning to become lightheaded and only barely registers Phainon shifting his hand. He doesn't notice the movement until Phainon loosens his grip on Mydei to slide his fingers down the sensitive inside of Mydei's palm, blunt nails raking gently along the skin. A low goan escapes Mydei, muffled by Phainon's mouth, and he can feel the curve of Phainon's smile against his lips. His hips buck upward into Phainon's hand unbidden, and the feeling of their cocks sliding against each other chases all other thoughts away.

"Mydei," Phainon breathes out when he draws back, his word half groan and half whisper against Mydei's lips. He doesn't give Mydei enough time to catch his breath before he leans in again, as if spurred on by whatever debauched expression is on Mydei's face.

Mydei tries to reply - to say something, anything - but Phainon stops him with another deep, heated kiss. The tempo is entirely in Phainon's control as the room spins around Mydei, the water is overly warm against his skin, a flush burns across his face and down his neck, and yet Phainon has the audacity to look so entirely taken by the sight.

"Mydei," Phainon says again, against Mydei's lips. This time, the word is softer. There's something in the way he says it, something heavy, yearning, *aching* -

Phainon grinds down against Mydei at the same time as he strokes their cocks just so, as if purposefully trying to prevent Mydei from replying, and Mydei can do nothing but moan low against Phainon. Static stars spark and envelop his vision as an orgasm takes him by surprise, the pleasure burning in his core suddenly shooting to a crescendo and snapping at the apex.

Mydei is still coming back to his senses when he feels Phainon jerk against him and follow suit, his skin overly warm against Mydei as he moans something under his breath and then drops his head against Mydei's shoulder.

Mydei's chest heaves with effort as he tries to catch his breath, and he can feel Phainon's equally heavy breathing against him. Phainon gingerly lets

go of their cocks, but his fingers laced with Mydei's tighten and he doesn't make any move to raise his head.

All Mydei does is sigh into Phainon's damp hair and lift his other hand from Phainon's hip to straighten the pale strands in front him, occasionally mirroring Phainon's movements from before and rubbing flecks of blood from them.

The water around them is still as warm and clean as it was when they entered, as if no time has passed at all, but both of them know that Phainon's trial approaches. Their embrace is warm and comfortable. With Phainon lying almost entirely on Mydei, the rest of the world and all their burdens - the Flame-Chase Journey, matters of the Chrysos Heirs, Coreflames, gods - all feel so far away.

"... I suppose I should go," Phainon mutters against Mydei's shoulder, eventually. And yet he lingers, minutely pressing closer against Mydei, as if hiding his face can block out the weight of the trial before him. If there is more to Phainon's sentence that lingers unsaid, he doesn't offer it - and Mydei allows the moment to pass unquestioned.

Mydei indulges him for a few more long moments before he purposefully opens his hand to let go of Phainon's. He feels the way Phainon tenses at the deliberate movement and chuckles quietly, running his fingers through Phainon's hair to coax him to raise his head.

When Phainon does, sitting back up and looking at Mydei with a heavy expression that doesn't reveal what he's thinking, Mydei meets his stare head on. He has always looked at Phainon this way - he knows what strength looks like, and he is unafraid to let Phainon know that's what he sees. The lingering worry Mydei has is pushed to the side in favor of showing Phainon that look of recognition.

"Go," Mydei says quietly, still looking up at Phainon. Phainon squeezes his hand once, and then slowly lets go. His expression relaxes slightly, and he gives Mydei a weary - if grateful - smile. Mydei holds his gaze for a moment longer and then raises his chin, an unpresumptuous fearlessness in

his expression, as if the outcome will be a foregone conclusion. “Fulfill your destiny, Deliverer.”

End Notes

Yes, I have seen the 3.1 trailers … and I am excited to see how we feel about this fic after the patch

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!